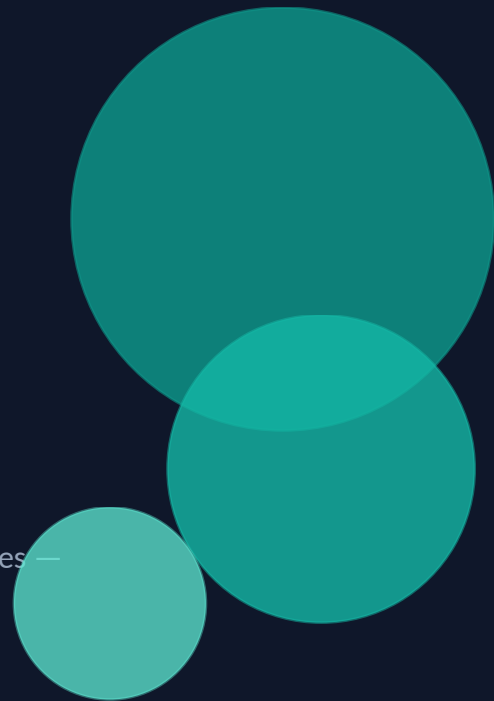


TIOBE INDEX

March 2026

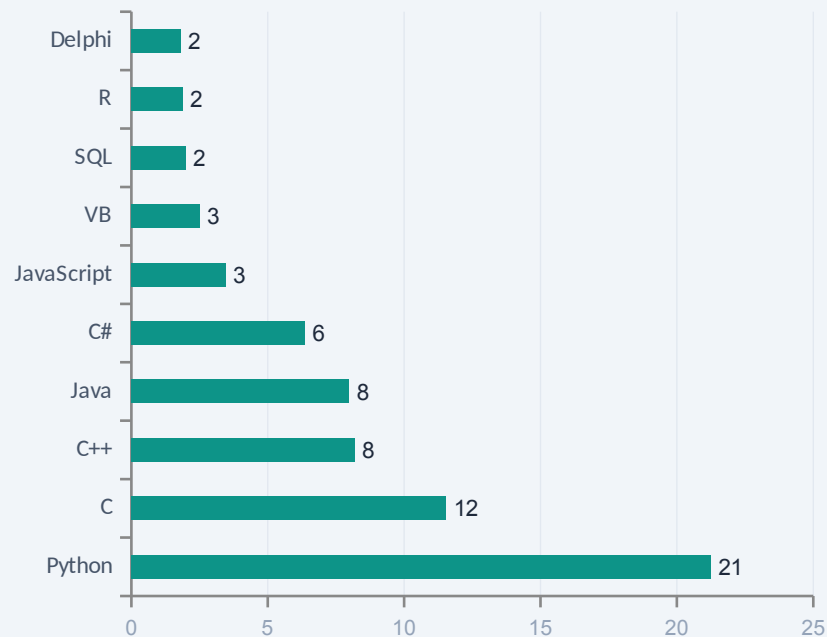
Programming Language Popularity Rankings

Ratings based on search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites — reflecting global engineer interest, not code volume.



Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

#	Lang	Rating	YoY
1	Python	21.25%	+4.25%
2	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	VB	2.50%	-0.02%
8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	Delphi	1.80%	-0.36%
▲ RISERS			
11	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	Assembly	1.29%	+0.42%
18	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%



Top 4 languages — Python, C, C++, Java — hold **48.97%** of the total index

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

RISERS

+13

Perl

24th → 11th

+1.05%

Biggest rank jump in the index

+7

R

16th → 9th

+0.94%

Data science demand surge

+6

Swift

26th → 20th

+0.44%

Apple ecosystem growth

+2

C

4th → 2nd

+2.02%

Systems programming revival

0

C#

5th → 5th

+1.49%

Stable with positive momentum

FALLERS

-9

Go

7th → 16th

-1.49%

Largest absolute drop in top 20

-1

C++

2nd → 3rd

-2.90%

Biggest % drop among top 5

-1

Java

3rd → 4th

-2.37%

Continued multi-decade slide

-2

Kotlin

20th → 22nd

-0.18%

Cross-platform framework competition

-5

PHP

13th → 18th

-0.25%

Web backend market erosion

Go's decline from 7th to 16th contrasts sharply with its 2016 Language of the Year win — Rust may be absorbing systems-programming mindshare.

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JS	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

C: The Unshakeable Constant

The only language to hold top-2 across all nine measurement points from 1986 to 2026. From #1 in 1986 to #2 in 2026.

Python's 25-Year Ascent

Unranked in 1986, outside top 30 in 2001, top 10 by 2006, #1 by 2021 — a 25-year journey from obscurity to dominance.

Java's Long Decline

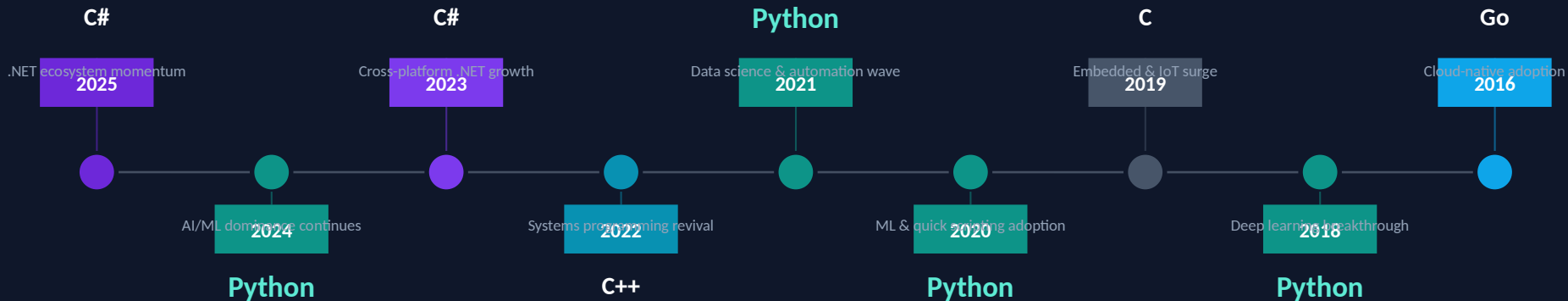
Peaked at 25%+ (2005–2018) dominating the index. Now at sub-8% as cloud and scripting languages erode its lead.

Lisp: From #2 to #26

The language that pioneered AI research now ranks 26th — a cautionary tale of ecosystem lock-in vs. market evolution.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times – More Than Any Other Language

Awarded annually to the language with the largest gain in TIOBE ratings during a calendar year



6×

Python wins

2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024

2×

C# wins

2023 & 2025 — recent momentum

9 yrs

since Go's win

2016 winner now at 16th rank

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

1

Python's Dominance vs. Decline Trajectory

21.25% rating — more than double C — but posting the largest YoY drop (~2.59 pts) among the top 5. AI/ML demand sustains it, yet growth has plateaued. Don't assume continued linear rise.

2

C's Resurgence — A Structural Shift

C surged to #2 (+2.02 pts YoY), the largest absolute gain in the top 20. This aligns with IoT, embedded systems, and security-critical infrastructure growth — not a cyclical blip.

3

Legacy Language Revival Is Real

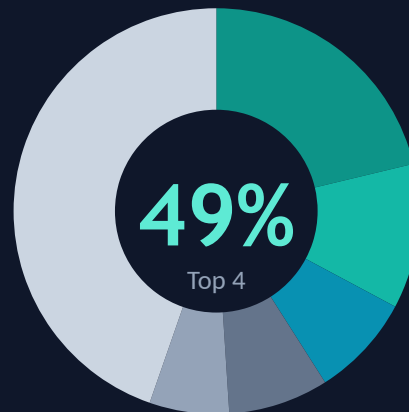
Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7 ranks), and Fortran (holding top 15) show entrenched scientific and data communities aren't shrinking — they're just quiet. Factor them into hiring for specialized roles.

4

Go's Fall Is a Warning Sign

Go fell from 7th to 16th — the biggest rank drop in the index. Rust's steady presence at 14th suggests systems programming mindshare is being redistributed. Reassess Go-centric investments.

Index Concentration



Strategic Implication

Concentration risk is real — nearly half the index is top-4 languages. A diversified stack hedge (Python for AI, C for systems, C#/.NET for enterprise) balances momentum with stability.